

Week 2: Big Bands & the Swing Era

Quiz Study Guide

MUS/AAS 262 — Jazz History: Many Sounds, Many Voices
The Big Bands and Swing (1925–1945)

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1 Knowledge Tracker

Move items between sections as you study. The goal is to get everything into Green.

Green — Know From Memory

- ☐ (move items here as you master them)

Yellow — Partial / Need Notes

- ☐ Fletcher Henderson = innovated 15-piece big band format (~1924): 3 trumpets, 3 trombones, 5 saxes, 4 rhythm (piano, bass, drums, guitar)
- ☐ Duke Ellington coined “swing” via “It Don’t Mean a Thing If It Ain’t Got That Swing” (1931 composition, 1932 recording)
- ☐ “Ellington effect” = coined by Billy Strayhorn (1940); moaning, sustaining passages underneath trumpet melodies
- ☐ Contrafact = writing a new melody over a pre-existing chord progression to create a new composition
- ☐ “Rhythm changes” = chord progression from Gershwin’s “I Got Rhythm”; most commonly used progression in jazz alongside the blues

Red — Didn’t Know / Got Wrong

- ☐ Cotton Club: Ellington was resident composer in Harlem in the 1930s; all performers were Black, all patrons were white
- ☐ “Jungle style” = pejorative 1930s term for Ellington’s West African-inspired sound (plunger mutes, growling brass)
- ☐ Papa Joe Jones moved four-on-the-floor from bass drum to hi-hat, creating lighter swing feel; influenced bebop
- ☐ Benny Goodman = “King of Swing” (controversial; Black bandleaders overlooked); one of first to integrate his band (hired Lionel Hampton, Teddy Wilson, Charlie Christian, Cootie Williams)
- ☐ Saxophone replaced clarinet as most prominent wind instrument in jazz during swing era

Not Yet Tested

- ☐ Duke Ellington (1899–1974): born Washington, DC, upper-middle-class, classically trained; led orchestra 50 years (1923–1974)
- ☐ Count Basie (1904–1984): born New Jersey; took over Benny Moten’s band in Kansas City after Moten died (1935)
- ☐ Head arrangements = compositions created spontaneously in rehearsal “from the top of your head”
- ☐ Riff = short melodic phrase that’s repeated; Basie placed much greater emphasis on riffs
- ☐ Basie = minimalist (opposite of Ellington’s elaborate compositions and harmonies)
- ☐ All-American Rhythm Section (1937–1947): Basie (piano), Papa Joe Jones (drums), Walter Page (bass), Freddie Green (guitar)

- ☐ Four on the floor = bass drum hitting every quarter note; originated as “Big Four” in New Orleans jazz
- ☐ Billy Strayhorn wrote “Take the A Train” (not Ellington); became Ellington’s theme song in the 1940s
- ☐ Ellington’s five compositional functions: dance songs, jungle style (Cotton Club), mood pieces, pop tunes, abstract compositions
- ☐ Big Three tenor saxophonists: Coleman Hawkins (Henderson’s band), Lester Young (Basie’s band), Ben Webster (Ellington’s band)
- ☐ Johnny Hodges = Ellington’s lead alto saxophonist; dominant voice on alto until Charlie Parker in 1940s
- ☐ 32-bar AABA form = standard popular song form (B section = bridge)
- ☐ Billie Holiday (1915–1959): voice like an instrument/horn; exchanged nicknames with Lester Young (“Lady Day” and “Prez”)
- ☐ Ella Fitzgerald (1917–1996): “First Lady of Song”; four-octave range; master of scat singing
- ☐ Coleman Hawkins = “Father of the Jazz Tenor Saxophone”; vertical approach (playing up and down chord changes)
- ☐ Lester Young = “cool” sound; horizontal/melodic approach (contrast with Hawkins’ “hot”/vertical style)
- ☐ Swing music spread via radio, movies, and recordings; jazz WAS popular music in the 1930s because it was dance music
- ☐ Lindy Hop = popular swing-era dance style
- ☐ Harlem Renaissance saw Ellington as “New School” of Black Americans vs. Armstrong as “old school”
- ☐ LeRoi Jones (Amiri Baraka), *Blues People* (1963) = one of first books by an African American scholar on jazz history
- ☐ Gunther Schuller wrote *The Swing Era* (companion to *Early Jazz*)
- ☐ “Strange Fruit” (1939) = one of first protest songs in jazz, about lynching; written by Abel Meeropol; Holiday’s record company tried to ban it

2 The Era: Big Bands and Swing (1925–1945)

2.1 What This Movement Contributes

1. **Big Band Format** — Fletcher Henderson created the 15-piece template (~1924) that remains standard today
2. **Swing as Dance Music** — jazz became America’s popular music; people danced to it (Lindy Hop)
3. **The Saxophone’s Rise** — saxophone overtook clarinet as the dominant jazz wind instrument
4. **Compositional Sophistication** — Ellington elevated jazz composition (mood pieces, abstract works, descriptive pieces)
5. **The Soloist Within the Ensemble** — star soloists emerged from big bands (Hawkins, Young, Webster, Hodges)
6. **Contrafact Tradition** — jazz musicians began building new compositions on existing chord progressions (“rhythm changes”)

2.2 Era Characteristics

- **Rhythmic Feel:** Swing rhythm; four-on-the-floor (bass drum or hi-hat); beats 2 and 4
- **Ensemble Style:** Large bands (15 pieces); section-based writing (brass vs. reeds); call-and-response between sections
- **Improvisation:** Extended solos within arranged frameworks; head arrangements (Basie) vs. elaborate compositions (Ellington)
- **Key Forms:** 32-bar AABA (popular songs, “rhythm changes”); 12-bar blues still prominent
- **Technology:** Radio broadcasts, sound film (early 1930s), and recordings spread swing nationally and globally
- **Sound:** Section playing (saxes in unison, brass in unison); “hot” vs. “cool” soloist approaches

2.3 Key Concepts

- **Big Band Format:** 3 trumpets, 3 trombones, 5 saxophones, 4 rhythm (piano, bass, drums, guitar)
- **Ellington Effect:** Moaning, sustaining accompaniment passages underneath trumpet melodies (coined by Billy Strayhorn)
- **Jungle Style:** Pejorative 1930s term for Ellington’s West African-inspired sound; plunger mutes, growling brass (Bubber Miley)
- **Head Arrangement:** Composition created spontaneously during rehearsal; melody often emerges last
- **Riff:** Short melodic phrase that repeats; central to Basie’s approach
- **Contrafact:** New melody written over pre-existing chord progression (e.g., “Cottontail” uses “I Got Rhythm” changes)
- **Rhythm Changes:** Chord progression from Gershwin’s “I Got Rhythm”; most commonly used progression in jazz alongside blues
- **Four on the Floor:** Bass drum (or hi-hat) on every quarter note; Papa Joe Jones moved it from bass drum to hi-hat

- **Hot vs. Cool:** “Hot” (Hawkins, Webster) = aggressive, vertical, influenced by Armstrong; “Cool” (Young) = relaxed, horizontal, melodic
- **Vertical vs. Horizontal Improvisation:** Vertical = playing up and down chord tones (Hawkins); Horizontal = playing melodic lines across chords (Young)

3 Artists and Songs — Syllabus Listening

3.1 Duke Ellington — “Take the A Train” (1941)

Era: Swing / Big Band (1940s)

Key Facts

1. Written by Billy Strayhorn (NOT Ellington); became Ellington’s theme song in the 1940s
2. Strayhorn was Ellington’s pianist and composer-collaborator
3. Features the “Ellington effect” — moaning, sustaining passages underneath the melody
4. Notable use of dynamics throughout the arrangement
5. Demonstrates Ellington’s ability to showcase band as a cohesive orchestral unit
6. 32-bar AABA form

Instrumentation: Full big band — trumpet section, trombone section, saxophone section, rhythm section (piano, bass, drums, guitar)

Song Form: 32-bar AABA

Listen For: Catchy opening melody (trumpet), Ellington effect (sustained sax/trombone passages under melody), dynamic contrasts (loud/soft), full band vs. solo sections, polished arrangement, swinging rhythm section

3.2 Duke Ellington — “Cottontail” (1940)

Era: Swing / Big Band (1940s)

Key Facts

1. Based on “I Got Rhythm” chord changes — a **contrafact**
2. Features tenor saxophonist Ben Webster as primary soloist
3. Ben Webster exemplifies the “hot sound” on saxophone, influenced by Louis Armstrong’s hot trumpet style
4. Webster was one of the Big Three tenor saxophonists (with Hawkins and Young)
5. Demonstrates how jazz musicians built new compositions on pre-existing chord progressions
6. 32-bar AABA form (same structure as “I Got Rhythm”)

Instrumentation: Full big band with Ben Webster (tenor sax) as featured soloist

Song Form: 32-bar AABA (rhythm changes / “I Got Rhythm” chord progression)

Listen For: Ben Webster’s “hot” tenor sax solo (aggressive, breathy, Armstrong-influenced), new melody over familiar chord changes, call-and-response between sax section and brass section, energetic swing feel, arranged ensemble passages between solos

3.3 Count Basie — “One O’Clock Jump” (1937)

Era: Swing / Big Band / Kansas City Jazz (late 1930s)

Key Facts

1. A blues-based **head arrangement** — created spontaneously during rehearsal, not from a written score
2. The melody doesn’t appear until near the very end of the piece (characteristic of head arrangements)
3. Features Lester Young on tenor saxophone with a “cool” sound (contrast with Ben Webster’s “hot” sound)
4. Demonstrates Basie’s minimalist piano style
5. Papa Joe Jones moves four-on-the-floor from bass drum to hi-hat, creating lighter, more buoyant feeling
6. Freddie Green’s guitar provides the underlying four-feel rhythm
7. Texture variety: band drops out during quieter solos, Papa Joe Jones switches between ride cymbal and hi-hat

Instrumentation: Full big band — All-American Rhythm Section: Basie (piano), Papa Joe Jones (drums), Walter Page (bass), Freddie Green (guitar); plus horn sections with Lester Young (tenor sax) featured

Song Form: 12-bar blues; head arrangement structure (solos first, melody last)

Listen For: Lester Young’s “cool” relaxed tenor sax tone, Basie’s spare/minimalist piano comping, hi-hat timekeeping (not bass drum), Freddie Green’s steady guitar pulse, texture changes (band drops out for piano solo, swells for ensemble), riff-based melody arriving late in the arrangement, blues form throughout

3.4 Count Basie / Lester Young — “Oh! Lady Be Good” (1936)

Era: Swing / Big Band / Kansas City Jazz (mid-1930s)

Key Facts

1. Features Lester Young as primary soloist — quintessential example of his “cool” approach
2. Lester Young’s horizontal/melodic improvisation style contrasts with Coleman Hawkins’ vertical/chordal approach
3. Young played in Count Basie’s band; one of the Big Three tenor saxophonists
4. Young’s relaxed, laid-back phrasing influenced the “cool jazz” movement of the 1950s
5. Exchanged nicknames with Billie Holiday: she called him “Prez” (president of the saxophone), he called her “Lady Day”

Instrumentation: Small group or big band with Lester Young (tenor sax) featured

Song Form: 32-bar AABA (standard popular song form)

Listen For: Lester Young’s light, airy, “cool” tone (contrast with Hawkins’ heavier vibrato), melodic/horizontal approach to improvisation (lines flow across chord changes rather than outlining individual chords), relaxed behind-the-beat phrasing, smooth legato lines, minimal vibrato compared to Hawkins

3.5 Coleman Hawkins — “Body and Soul” (1939)

Era: Swing (late 1930s)

Key Facts

1. Considered the first great jazz tenor saxophone solo
2. Hawkins = “Father of the Jazz Tenor Saxophone”; nicknames “Hawk” and “Bean” (for being intellectual)
3. Features mostly improvisation with only brief quotation of the original melody
4. Demonstrates **vertical approach** to improvisation — playing up and down chord changes
5. Hawkins emerged from Fletcher Henderson’s band (1923–1934), spent 1934–1939 in London, recorded this upon return
6. Extended saxophone technique into the altissimo register (extreme high range)
7. Extensive vibrato throughout notes; smooth tone with jumping quality and texture
8. Tenor saxophone often considered the instrument closest to the human voice
9. Hawkins was pivotal in the transition from swing to bebop; reportedly the first to hire Thelonious Monk

Instrumentation: Tenor saxophone (Hawkins) with rhythm section (piano, bass, drums)

Song Form: 32-bar AABA; Hawkins largely abandons the melody and improvises over the chord changes

Listen For: Almost entirely improvised (melody barely stated), vertical/chordal improvisation (arpeggios moving through chord tones), extensive vibrato, altissimo register passages, smooth but active melodic movement, romantic ballad interpretation, lush tone quality

3.6 Benny Goodman — “Sing, Sing, Sing” (1937)

Era: Swing (late 1930s)

Key Facts

1. One of the most iconic pieces in jazz history
2. Goodman (1909–1986) = “King of Swing”; born in Chicago to Jewish immigrant parents from Poland
3. Classically trained clarinetist who started playing professionally at age 14
4. Unique as a drum feature centered around Gene Krupa’s drumming

5. Over seven minutes long, split across two sides of a record (unusual for the three-minute standard)
6. The drum rhythm is one of the most frequently quoted elements in American music
7. Fletcher Henderson was Goodman's arranger (same Henderson who worked with Armstrong and Hawkins)
8. "King of Swing" title was controversial — Black bandleaders (Ellington, Basie, Henderson, Cab Calloway) were overlooked
9. Goodman was one of the first white bandleaders to integrate his band: hired Teddy Wilson (piano), Lionel Hampton (vibraphone), Charlie Christian (guitar), Cootie Williams (trumpet)
10. Goodman's clarinet: beautiful classical tone combined with blues feeling and active melodic movement

Instrumentation: Full big band with Gene Krupa (drums) and Benny Goodman (clarinet) as featured soloists

Song Form: Extended form (unusual for the era); built around recurring drum patterns

Listen For: Gene Krupa's driving tom-tom rhythm (the iconic drum pattern), extensive call-and-response between drums and horns, Goodman's clarinet solo (classical tone + blues feeling), extended length (7+ minutes), building energy and intensity, drum-dominated texture (unusual for jazz)

3.7 Billie Holiday — "God Bless the Child" (1942)

Era: Swing (early 1940s)

Key Facts

1. Holiday's most famous self-composed song
2. Billie Holiday (1915–1959): died young at age 44
3. Voice was like an instrument/horn — fragile and distinct timbre, relatively small vocal range but immense feeling
4. Vocal characteristics: very legato phrasing, words spilling into each other, unique timbre, yearning quality, wide vowel placement
5. Exchanged nicknames with Lester Young: she was "Lady Day," he was "Prez"
6. Catapulted jazz vocals to new level of fame
7. Raw emotional quality and unique tone distinguished her from other vocalists
8. Use of dynamics: quieter moments building to louder endings
9. Voice described as woeful, wistful, reminiscent, sober
10. 32-bar ABA form

Instrumentation: Voice (Holiday) with small ensemble accompaniment

Song Form: 32-bar ABA

Listen For: Legato phrasing (words flow into each other), unique/fragile vocal timbre (horn-like quality), yearning emotional quality, dynamic contrast (quiet to loud), behind-the-beat phrasing, wide vowel placement, minimal but effective vibrato, storytelling delivery

3.8 Ella Fitzgerald — “Blue Skies” (1958)

Era: Swing / Post-Swing (late 1950s)

from Ella Fitzgerald Sings the Irving Berlin Songbook

Key Facts

1. Ella Fitzgerald (1917–1996) = “First Lady of Song”
2. Four-octave vocal range; very clear, big voice
3. Considered the master of scat singing (though Louis Armstrong created the technique)
4. Uses chromaticism and runs up and down chords — vertical approach similar to Coleman Hawkins
5. Incorporates humor through quotation in her scatting (quotes the bridal march, Gershwin tunes, etc.)
6. Approach contrasts with Holiday’s: Fitzgerald = virtuosic/vertical (like Hawkins); Holiday = emotional/intimate (like Webster in ballads)

Instrumentation: Voice (Fitzgerald) with ensemble/big band accompaniment

Song Form: 32-bar AABA (standard Irving Berlin song form); includes extended scat sections

Listen For: Scat singing (improvised syllables), chromaticism and rapid melodic runs, four-octave range on display, quotation of other melodies within scat solos (humor), clear and powerful tone, rhythmic precision, contrast with Holiday’s fragile intimacy — Fitzgerald is virtuosic and exuberant

4 Additional Pieces Discussed in Class

Not on the syllabus listening list but discussed in lecture — may appear on quizzes.

4.1 Duke Ellington — “It Don’t Mean a Thing If It Ain’t Got That Swing” (1932)

1. Gave the entire swing movement its name
2. Composed 1931, recorded 1932
3. 32-bar AABA song form
4. Features elaborate singing and an alto saxophone solo by Johnny Hodges
5. Hodges was Ellington’s lead alto saxophonist and dominant voice on alto until Charlie Parker

Listen For: AABA form, Johnny Hodges’ alto sax solo, vocal scatting, the word “swing” used to define the rhythmic feel of an entire era

4.2 Duke Ellington — “Daybreak Express” (1934)

1. Abstract composition deliberately mimicking the sound of a train on tracks
2. Uses chromatic scales to create intensity and the Doppler effect
3. Demonstrates Ellington’s compositional ambition beyond dance music — a descriptive/programmatic piece

Listen For: Train sounds/imagery, chromatic scales, building intensity, Doppler-like effects, orchestral approach to jazz composition

4.3 Duke Ellington — “East St. Louis Toodle-oo” (1927)

1. Best example of the “Ellington effect”
2. Features Bubber Miley’s trumpet with moaning saxophone and tuba accompaniment underneath
3. Miley used a plunger mute and growling technique = “jungle style”

Listen For: Plunger-muted trumpet (Bubber Miley), growling brass, moaning sustained accompaniment under trumpet melody, dark timbral quality

4.4 Billie Holiday — “Strange Fruit” (1939)

1. One of the first protest songs in jazz history — about lynching in America
2. Written by Abel Meeropol (not Holiday)

3. Record company tried to ban her from performing it; she refused and continued, leading to jail time
4. Sung in minor key, straightforward delivery, no vibrato, confrontational
5. Ominous piano introduction; meant to make audience uncomfortable
6. Matter-of-fact tone was mocking and accusatory

Listen For: Minor key, ominous piano intro, absence of vibrato (unlike her other singing), stark/confrontational delivery, uncomfortable silences, dramatic contrast with typical swing-era entertainment music

4.5 Coleman Hawkins — “Ruby My Dear” (1957, with Thelonious Monk)

1. Showcases Hawkins’ romantic ballad style later in his career
2. Stays within chord tones; demonstrates unbelievable tone quality
3. Hawkins was supportive of new music and reportedly the first to hire Monk

Listen For: Romantic ballad interpretation, rich warm tone, vibrato, chord-tone-based improvisation, interplay with Monk’s angular piano

4.6 Ben Webster — “Time On My Hands” (mid-1950s)

1. Webster known more as a balladeer than uptempo player
2. Vocal quality with crying sound and extensive use of air/breath in tone
3. Very early and fast vibrato adding yearning quality
4. Album *Soulville* recommended for more of this style

Listen For: Breathily/airy tone, crying quality, fast vibrato, extreme tenderness and nuance, vocal-like phrasing, dynamic subtlety

5 Listening Response Template

Name, composer, and year are PROVIDED on the quiz. Focus on what you HEAR. Aim for 5 observations:

1. **Instrumentation/Ensemble** — Big band or small group? Which sections (brass, reeds, rhythm)? Who is the soloist?
2. **Era/Style** — Swing, Kansas City, big band? What clues? (full band = swing era; riff-based = Basie; lush orchestration = Ellington; drum feature = Goodman)
3. **Rhythm/Feel** — Swinging? Four-on-the-floor (bass drum or hi-hat)? Riff-based? Light/heavy?
4. **Melody/Improvisation** — Head arrangement or composed? Contrafact? Vertical or horizontal soloist? Scat singing? Hot or cool?
5. **Texture/Form/Special** — 32-bar AABA or 12-bar blues? Call-and-response between sections? Ellington effect? Dynamic contrasts? Plunger mute? Extended length?
6. **Emotion/Context** — Dance music or art music? Protest? How does it connect to readings?

Template: “This piece features [ensemble type] with [soloist] as the primary voice. The style is [era/style] based on [clues]. The form is [form], evidenced by [what you hear]. A notable feature is [detail], which connects to [course concept].”

6 General Understanding

6.1 Movement’s Place in History

- Big band format (Henderson, ~1924) standardized jazz into large ensemble music
- Swing era = jazz as America’s popular music; people danced to it
- Technology (radio, film, recordings) spread swing nationally and globally
- Saxophone overtook clarinet as dominant wind instrument; planted seeds for modern jazz
- Star soloists emerged from big bands, setting the stage for small-group bebop in the 1940s

6.2 Cultural Context

- Cotton Club: Ellington’s creative incubator, but with racist dynamic (Black performers, white-only audience)
- “King of Swing” controversy: Benny Goodman (white) received title while Black innovators were overlooked
- Goodman also one of first to integrate his band — hired Hampton, Wilson, Christian, Williams despite criticism
- Harlem Renaissance: Ellington = “New School” of Black Americans; Armstrong = “old school”
- 1930s paradox: African American music celebrated while African Americans themselves were not embraced by society
- LeRoi Jones (Amiri Baraka), *Blues People* (1963): one of first African American scholarly treatments of jazz history

6.3 Musical Evolution

- Ellington: elaborate compositions, orchestral ambition, five compositional functions, “Ellington effect”
- Basie: minimalist, head arrangements, riff-based, lighter swing (hi-hat instead of bass drum)
- Contrafact tradition: new melodies over existing chord progressions became fundamental jazz practice
- Hot vs. Cool dichotomy: Hawkins/Webster (hot, vertical) vs. Young (cool, horizontal) — this tension carries into bebop and cool jazz
- Papa Joe Jones’ hi-hat innovation directly influenced bebop drumming in the 1940s

6.4 Key Tensions

- **Composed vs. Spontaneous:** Ellington’s elaborate scores vs. Basie’s head arrangements
- **Hot vs. Cool:** Hawkins/Webster’s aggressive approach vs. Young’s laid-back melodicism
- **Entertainment vs. Art:** Swing was dance music, but Ellington pushed toward abstract composition (“Daybreak Express”)
- **Black Innovation, White Recognition:** Henderson arranged for Goodman; Goodman got the “King of Swing” title
- **Virtuosity vs. Emotion:** Fitzgerald’s four-octave scat vs. Holiday’s fragile intimacy